Austin Propositions Explained

A $260M parks bond — AGAINST

Borrows $260 million for pools, trails, rec centers, park buildings and new parkland, repaid through property taxes.

FOR
Repairs four pools, adds playscapes and trails, and buys new parkland. Taxes for it wouldn't start until around 2033, at about $40 a year on a typical home.

AGAINST
The council skipped its own process of one planned bond election every six years, and finance staff said 2026 is too soon under the city's debt limits. The mayor called the project list district favors. Austin still has $715M in approved bonds it hasn't spent, and voters rejected the Prop Q tax increase a year ago.

My pick: Against. Good intentions, bad execution. Finish the earlier bonds first, then come back in 2028.

B $35M library bond — AGAINST

Borrows $35 million to expand the Hampton Branch in Oak Hill and build a new branch in Colony Park in East Austin.

FOR
Costs only a few dollars a year, and Colony Park doesn't have a library nearby.

AGAINST
Same problem as Prop A: it skipped the city's own bond process and comes while $715M in earlier bonds is still unspent.

My pick: Against. Good intentions, bad execution. It's small, so voting for it is reasonable too.

C Redistricting commission rules — FOR

Confirms the citizen commission that draws council districts is independent of the City Council, makes it easier for students to serve on it, and clarifies how vacancies are filled.

FOR
Keeps politicians from drawing their own districts. Students get easier eligibility rules.

AGAINST
Also lets city staff talk to the commission outside meetings, which some see as room for influence.

My pick: For. More independence for whoever draws the lines.

D Drop the weekly meeting rule — AGAINST

Removes the charter rule that the City Council must meet at least once a week.

FOR
Gives the council flexibility to set its own schedule.

AGAINST
Fewer guaranteed public meetings means fewer chances for the public to watch and speak.

My pick: Against. Keep the guaranteed oversight.

E Drop setting council rules by ordinance — AGAINST

Removes the requirement that the council set its own rules and order of business by ordinance.

FOR
Lets the council change its procedures faster, with less red tape.

AGAINST
Ordinances are a formal, public process. Without it, the council can change its own rules more quietly.

My pick: Against, but low stakes. Same reasoning as D.

F Campaign donation limit fixes

FOR

A donor can give a council or mayor candidate at most $500 "per election." Prop F spells out that a general election, a runoff and a special election each count as a separate election. It also adjusts the $500 limit for inflation every January 1 instead of during the budget vote.

FOR

Ends confusion about whether a runoff gets its own limit, and puts the inflation update on a fixed date. Both of Austin's main papers, the Statesman and the Chronicle, recommend yes.

AGAINST

A donor can give $500 for the general election and another $500 if there's a runoff.

My pick: For. It doesn't change who can vote or how elections work. It only clarifies the donation rules.

G Petition props only in even-year Novembers

FOR

Today a citizen petition can force a vote at the next election date, including a May or odd-year election that has only props on the ballot (the 2021 camping ban vote was in May). Under Prop G, petition props go on the November ballot in even years, alongside the regular elections like this one. Nothing extra to vote in, and no separate trips to the polls.

FOR

Fewer props-only elections. Petition props get decided when the most people vote, and the city saves the cost of extra elections.

AGAINST

A petition might wait up to two years to reach voters. The Statesman recommends no for that reason. It only covers citizen petitions; the City Council can still call its own odd-year votes, like last year's Prop Q.

My pick: For. It cuts down on props-only elections.

H City Council hires the city attorney

AGAINST

Today the City Council hires the city manager, who runs the city day to day, and the manager hires the city attorney. Under Prop H, the council would hire and fire the attorney directly. The attorney's boss would change from one unelected manager to the 11 elected council members.

FOR

The attorney advises the council and defends the laws it passes, but works for the manager. That's a built-in conflict when the two disagree. More than 70% of Texas cities have the council hire the attorney, and supporters say it makes the attorney answer to people voters can remove.

AGAINST

Voters can already remove the council, and the council already controls the manager. Making the attorney answer to a council majority puts pressure on the attorney to give the legal answer six votes want. Austin voters rejected this in 2012 (51–49) and in earlier tries.

My pick: Against, but it's a close call. The council already has indirect control, and legal advice is safer one step removed from politics.

I Independent audit of city spending

FOR

Requires an outside review of city spending every five years and before any vote to raise the tax rate. The reviewer has to find more savings than the review costs.

FOR

A real check on how tax money is spent, required before the city asks voters for more.

AGAINST

The city already has a $5M+ efficiency review underway, and consultants could push cuts to libraries, parks or public health. It's backed by Save Austin Now, a conservative group, and a similar measure failed in 2018.

My pick: For. Checks on the money come first, especially before any future tax increase.

J Charter typo and cleanup fixes

FOR

Fixes typos and punctuation, and removes charter language that state law or court rulings have already overridden.

FOR

Housekeeping that keeps the charter accurate.

AGAINST

None really.

My pick: For.